

Lantern Deckbuilder Project – Agent Instructions & Content Guide

This document provides a comprehensive design brief for the **Lantern Deckbuilder** project, a dark survival deckbuilding roguelite inspired by *Kingdom Death: Monster* (KDM). It outlines gameplay pillars, data architecture, and a broad set of content packs inspired by the core game, its expansions, and wanderer characters. Use this as a permanent reference for agents (human and AI) working on the project.

1. Core Philosophy and Gameplay Pillars

1. **Survival horror tone:** The world is brutal and unforgiving, with visceral combat, traumatic events and ominous lore. The art and writing should evoke dread and desperation, even in heroic moments.
2. **Branching hunt map:** Each run is a branching chain of encounters (fights, events, resource caches and craft nodes) reminiscent of *Slay the Spire*.
3. **Deck as body and gear:** The player's deck represents their physical skills, equipment, injuries, and memories. New cards are gained through crafting or events; wound cards clog the deck; disorders alter behaviour.
4. **Equipment crafting:** Monsters drop parts (bone, hide, organ, etc.). These resources craft weapons, armour and trinkets that add, remove or modify cards rather than just increasing stats.
5. **Persistent settlement:** Each run grants permanent currency ("settlement memory") that unlocks upgrades, research, monster knowledge and inherited traits. Dead survivors leave behind legacies (cards, gear, scars) for the next generation.

Agents must adhere to these pillars when adding or modifying content or systems.

2. Data Architecture

All content lives in **content packs** under `src/data/contentPacks/`. Each pack exports a single default object with the following fields:

```
{
  id: "coreInspired",           // unique identifier
  displayName: "Core Inspired Pack", // human-readable name
  role: "core",                 // core, expansion, nemesis, wanderer, etc.
  monsters: [/* monster definitions */],
  gear: [/* equipment definitions */],
  resources: [/* resource definitions */],
  fightingArts: [/* active or passive skill cards */],
  disorders: [/* curse cards */],
```

```

events: [/* settlement or hunt events */],
settlementLocations: [/* buildings and innovations */],
innovations: [/* research trees */],
wanderers: [/* special one-off survivors */],
patterns: [/* crafting patterns */],
legacyUnlocks: [/* permanent unlock triggers */]
}

```

A central `contentRegistry.js` should import all packs and export an array or registry for the rest of the game to consume. Agents should **not** hardcode KDM names or exact mechanics; instead, create *inspired* content with original names and mechanics that evoke the source material without infringement. For example, “White Lion” becomes “Pale Hunt Lion” and “Dung Beetle Knight” becomes “Chitin Crusader.”

3. Core-Inspired Pack

This pack loosely adapts the base game’s monsters and systems.

Monsters

- **Pale Hunt Lion:** Balanced early quarry; alternates between frontal charges and mauling swipes. Loot includes *hide*, *claw* and *sinew*.
- **Wailing Antelope:** Skittish herbivore that tramples and howls; can vomit bile to heal itself. Loot includes *horn*, *stomach lining* and *gall bladder* for resilience gear.
- **Ash Phoenix:** A huge bird with time-bending attacks; can burn cards from the survivor’s discard pile. Loot includes *ashen feathers*, *beaks* and *ashes* for ethereal weapons.
- **Cleaver Saint (Nemesis):** Masked butcher who revels in slaughter; inflicts bleed and fatigue; grants *blood tokens* used in rituals.
- **Armored Judge (Nemesis):** Knight who enforces cosmic law; uses tactical positioning and punishment beams; drops *aether steel*.

Gear & Fighting Arts

- **Bone Blades, Rawhide Armour:** Generic early weapons and armour that add simple attack and block cards.
- **Ashen Garb:** Mid-game armour set offering high evasion and the *Flare* card (deal damage and discard).
- **Time-Warping Feather Cloak:** Rare gear allowing the survivor to retain cards across turns.
- **Fighting Arts:**
 - **Berserker’s Lunge:** Attack card dealing more damage when the survivor has no block.
 - **Clutch Fighter:** Passive granting strength when below half HP.
 - **Tumble:** Passive allowing one free dodge per fight.
 - **Monster Claw Style:** Attacks apply bleed tokens.

Events

- **Hunters’ Dream:** A hallucination event; choose between knowledge or madness, gaining insight cards or insanity disorders.
- **Acid Rain:** The hunt path floods with corrosive rain; survivors may take damage or gain a rare *acid gland* resource.

- **Clinging Fog:** A thick mist hides monstrous traps; successful scouting yields hidden caches.

Settlement Locations & Innovations

- **Bone Smith:** Unlocks new bone weapons such as *chitin scrapers* and the *jawbone hammer*.
- **Lantern Oven:** Provides endurance buff and allows cooking certain organs into buffs.
- **Storyteller Lodge:** Grants fighting art choices at the start of a run.

Wanderers

Wanderers are unique survivors who may join briefly or leave behind heirlooms. Examples:

- **Blind Prophet:** Arrives bearing a prophetic scroll; offers an option to discard a card to foresee an upcoming monster attack.
- **Mysterious Drifter:** Trades rare *aether steel* for *blood tokens*; may teach a passive fighting art.
- **Ashen Child:** A mute child who starts with a rare time-warp cloak; if they die, their cloak becomes a legacy unlock.

4. Expansion-Inspired Packs

Each expansion pack introduces a new major monster (quarry or nemesis), associated gear and events, plus optional wanderers. Agents should design at least one monster, two armour/weapon sets, one new resource type, events, and a settlement innovation per pack.

The Bloated Godling Pack (Gorm-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Bloated Godling* – a lumbering infant deity that devours anything; alternates between rolls and thunderous roars.
- **Resources:** *gelatinous meat, electrified gut, milk glands*.
- **Gear:**
- **Gel Meat Suit:** Armour set providing high HP but lower agility; adds the *Slosh* block card.
- **Storm Lance:** Weapon that charges; deals extra damage if unused energy remains.
- **Innovation:** *Weather Weaving* – allows altering future hunt paths (swap nodes).
- **Event:** A flood of noxious milk threatens the settlement; survivors must wade through to collect resources or risk disease.

The Silk Matriarch Pack (Spidicules-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Silk Matriarch* – a colossal spider that spawns silkings; webs cards in the player's hand, rendering them unplayable unless cut free.
- **Resources:** *silk strands, venom glands, chitin shards*.
- **Gear:**
- **Silken Armour:** Adds cards that entangle the monster but risk self-binding.
- **Spinnerette Bow:** Ranged weapon that fires silk nets; stunned monsters cannot act for a turn.
- **Innovation:** *Cocoon Nursery* – train silk pets that can absorb one hit for you.
- **Event:** A webbed wanderer offers knowledge at the cost of being briefly immobilised.

The Bloom Knight Pack (Flower Knight-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Bloom Knight* – an enigmatic swordsman who guards a mystical garden; extremely fast and punishes those who attack without proper timing.
- **Resources:** *petal blades, nectar, prismatic pollen.*
- **Gear:**
- **Petal Cloak:** Grants *Riposte* cards that counter when attacked.
- **Nectar Scimitar:** Every third strike heals you slightly.
- **Innovation:** *Botanical Sanctum* – allows crafting healing balms.
- **Event:** The garden offers a choice: pluck a rare flower (gain gear) or leave it to ensure the Bloom Knight is less aggressive next time.

The Chitin Crusader Pack (Dung Beetle Knight-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Chitin Crusader* – a giant beetle who rolls a dung ball fused with metal and bone; uses the ball as shield and projectile.
- **Resources:** *scarab shell, fermented core, chitin shards.*
- **Gear:**
- **Chitin Armour:** High defence but inflicts fatigue cards.
- **Rolling Maul:** A heavy weapon; can be “charged” to release a massive attack that exhausts all other cards in hand.
- **Innovation:** *Fermentation Pits* – convert organ resources into powerful buff cards.
- **Event:** A dung avalanche threatens the settlement; survivors may craft makeshift shields or risk being buried.

The Drake Emperor Pack (Dragon King-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Drake Emperor* – an ancient dragon that changes the rules of the fight; phases transition between elemental attacks (fire, crystal, light).
- **Resources:** *ember scales, crystal marrow, luminescent eye.*
- **Gear:**
- **Ember Blade:** Deals area damage but burns your own block.
- **Crystal Prism Armour:** Reflects a portion of damage back at the monster.
- **Innovation:** *Drake Shrine* – unlocks permanent bonuses against draconic creatures (start with extra block).
- **Event:** A meteor falls; survivors may collect *crystal shards* or be scorched.

The Sun Sovereign Pack (Sunstalker-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Sun Sovereign* – a colossal turtle with a glowing shell; alternates between basking (vulnerable) and blinding flares (immune and deals area damage).
- **Resources:** *sunstone shell, refractive fins, radiant ichor.*
- **Gear:**
- **Sunstone Shield:** Provides a massive block card that persists across turns.
- **Ichor Spear:** Bleeds you when used but deals high damage.
- **Innovation:** *Solar Forge* – craft weapons that scale with sunlight; synergises with time-of-day mechanics if implemented.
- **Event:** A solar eclipse; survivors gain stealth for one node but risk losing their path.

The Pride King Pack (Lion God-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Pride King* – a heavily armoured lion with spiked mane; punishes survivors who hide behind armour by breaking it.
- **Resources:** *armoured mane, prideful heart, spike-laden claws.*
- **Gear:**
- **Pride Armour:** Grants huge defence but makes you vulnerable to humiliation events (draw a *Shame* card).
- **Spinebreaker Axe:** Ignores the monster's armour but costs survival.
- **Innovation:** *Monument to Hubris* – permanently increases settlementMemory gains but also increases monster difficulty.
- **Event:** Survivors are challenged by a prideful statue; winning grants a relic; losing curses their deck.

The Shadow Stalker Pack (Slenderman-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Shadow Stalker* – a silent tall figure who steals cards from the deck; uses dimension-hopping to avoid damage.
- **Resources:** *shadow filament, void essence, faceless mask.*
- **Gear:**
- **Voidwalker Armour:** Allows discarding cards to teleport behind the monster.
- **Faceless Whip:** Forces the monster to play a random intent from its deck.
- **Innovation:** *Hall of Mirrors* – provides random free dodges each fight.
- **Event:** A faceless wanderer offers to erase one traumatic card from your deck for a price.

The Regal Knight Pack (Lion Knight-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Regal Knight* – a theatrical duellist who invites survivors to partake in scripted battles; punishes those who break his "rules."
- **Resources:** *ornate armour, tarnished crown, stage props.*
- **Gear:**
- **Crown of Lies:** Adds cards that manipulate monster intent but causes disorders if misused.
- **Prop Sword:** Can feint, converting block into damage on your next attack.
- **Innovation:** *Opera House* – survivors gain extra settlementMemory when defeating a nemesis with style (no damage taken).
- **Event:** A theatre troupe arrives; survivors can put on a show to gain resources but risk ridicule (curse card).

The Wandering Killer Pack (Manhunter-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Wandering Killer* – a one-armoured gunman who stalks the settlement; uses ranged attacks and crippling traps.
- **Resources:** *scrap metal, sand grit, blood beads.*
- **Gear:**
- **Sandstorm Cloak:** Reduces accuracy of ranged attacks against you.
- **Scrap Revolver:** Adds *Shoot* cards with limited ammo.
- **Innovation:** *Gun Forge* – unlocks firearms and ballistic fighting arts.
- **Event:** A dusty stranger warns of an approaching sandstorm; survivors may prepare (gain block cards) or ignore (take damage).

The Masked Judge Pack (King's Man-inspired)

- **Monster:** *Masked Judge* – an enforcer of order who delivers verdicts; uses unpredictable decrees that can invert game rules (e.g. blocking damages you, attacking heals the monster).
- **Resources:** *law tablets, black pearls, sealed scrolls*.
- **Gear:**
- **Judgement Armour:** Adds cards that reflect status ailments onto attackers.
- **Gavel Hammer:** Deals increasing damage if used repetitively.
- **Innovation:** *Courthouse* – choose settlement laws that provide bonuses but impose restrictions (e.g. no ranged weapons this run).
- **Event:** Survivors are tried in a kangaroo court; they may plead guilty (lose resources) or challenge the judge (start a nemesis fight).

The Cruel Collector Pack (Butcher-inspired Nemesis)

- **Monster:** *Cruel Collector* – harvests trophies from survivors; uses hooks and chains; grows more powerful as he collects severed cards (healing cards removed from your deck).
- **Resources:** *trophy teeth, rusty chain, hooked blade*.
- **Gear:**
- **Chainmail Vest:** Adds *Rip and Tear* block cards that damage attackers.
- **Hooked Cleaver:** Grants the *Hook* card (pulls the monster, canceling its action).
- **Innovation:** *Trophy Hall* – survivors can exchange cards for permanent bonuses or gear.
- **Event:** Survivors find a trophy room filled with mementos; they may reclaim a lost card or take a curse for a powerful gear piece.

The Mirror Tyrant Pack (Hand-inspired Nemesis)

- **Monster:** *Mirror Tyrant* – a silent giant who tests survivors with reflections of themselves; counters their strongest attacks; punishes repeated moves.
- **Resources:** *mirror shard, pale skin, shattered essence*.
- **Gear:**
- **Reflective Aegis:** Turns the monster's damage into block for you once per fight.
- **Shattered Edge:** A weapon that grows stronger as you remove cards from your deck.
- **Innovation:** *Hall of Reflection* – survivors gain insight into monster intents (extra card draw when they play unique sequences).
- **Event:** A mirror maze confuses survivors; navigating it without repeating moves yields treasure; repeating moves triggers an ambush.

Additional Packs and Wanderers

Beyond these major expansions, design supplementary packs for **rare Wanderers**, crossover characters or one-off mini-bosses:

- **Deep Sea Deviant** (Smog Singers-inspired): monstrous singers who lure survivors with songs; gear adds sonic attacks; wanderers include a *Sirena* who trades voices for survival.
- **Feral Twins** (Crimson Crocodile-inspired): twin crocodiles acting as a duo; gear emphasises dual wielding; wanderer is a *Herald of the Flood* who foresees deluges.
- **Reaper's Herald** (Black Knight-inspired): a solitary knight with scythe; gear adds cards that instantly kill wounded monsters but curse survivors.
- **Gambler's Ghost** (Gambler-inspired): an ethereal entity inviting survivors to play games of fate; rewards or curses them; gear adds *Chance* cards that double or nullify effects.

Agents are encouraged to invent additional packs with similarly evocative themes. Each pack should offer a fresh mechanic (e.g. weather, mirrors, performance, feral duo) and integrate seamlessly with the core systems.

5. Development Workflow for Agents and Codex

1. **Design or update content pack files** in `src/data/contentPacks/` according to the structure above. Avoid direct KDM names; choose evocative synonyms or wholly original names.
 2. **Add the pack** to `contentRegistry.js` so that the game loads it.
 3. **Write or adjust logic** in `src/game/*` only when implementing new mechanics (e.g. weather, stealth). Keep modifications incremental; ensure `npm run build` passes.
 4. **Use Codex in stages.** For example: Stage 0.5 adds the content pack architecture; Stage 1 implements combat; Stage 2 adds the map; Stage 3 adds permanent progression; Stage 4 adds grave legacies; Stage 5 adds crafting; Stage 6 adds events and resources; Stage 7 adds monsters; Stage 8 polishes the UI. Each stage should be its own branch/commit.
 5. **Always run tests** (start the dev server and run through a combat) after each patch. Fix regressions immediately before moving on.
-

6. Legal and Creative Considerations

- This project is a private, fan-made prototype **inspired by** *Kingdom Death: Monster*. It must remain uncommercial and unpublished unless all IP is fully reskinned and original.
 - Do not reproduce exact names, rule text, art or campaign storylines. Use creative reinterpretations instead.
 - If ever published, replace all remaining KDM identifiers with fully original equivalents, and commission original art.
-

7. Conclusion

The **Lantern Deckbuilder** project aims to capture the oppressive beauty and tactical depth of survival horror miniatures games in a deckbuilding format. By following the guidelines and content structure outlined here, agents will be able to add a huge variety of monsters, gear, events and wanderers while keeping the gameplay balanced, expandable and legally safe.

Use this document as your compass when creating new content or instructing AI assistants. The more consistent the structure and themes, the easier it will be for Codex or human collaborators to navigate and expand upon the dark, lantern-lit world you are building.
